

Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC)

Rafiqui Shaheed Road, Karachi

Email: jpmc.edu.pk

INFORMED CONSENT FORM

Project Information

Field	Information
Project Title:	Health Literacy and Its Impact on Cancer Diagnosis and Treatment Pathways: A Cross-Sectional Study at Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre, Karachi
IRB Ref No:	[To be assigned by JPMC IRB]
Sponsor:	None
Principal Investigator:	Dr. Anita Vallacha
Organization:	Oncology Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC), Karachi
Phone:	0336-8025062
Other Investigators:	Prof. Dr. Ghulam Haider
Organization:	Oncology Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC), Karachi
Phone:	0300-2307257

Please read this consent form carefully before deciding whether to participate in this research study.

1. PURPOSE OF THIS RESEARCH STUDY

You are being asked to participate in a research study designed to understand how well cancer patients understand health information and how this affects their journey from diagnosis to treatment. In Pakistan, many patients are diagnosed with cancer at a late stage, which can make treatment more difficult. This may be related to a patient's ability to find, understand, and use health information to make decisions about their health, known as **health literacy**.

This study aims to assess the health literacy levels of cancer patients at JPMC and to understand how it relates to their knowledge of cancer symptoms, their ability to seek help, and their understanding of treatment side effects. The information gathered will help healthcare providers develop better educational materials and support for patients in the future.

2. PROCEDURES

If you agree to participate in this study, you will be asked to do the following:

- Participate in a **single face-to-face interview** that will take approximately **30–45 minutes**.
- Answer questions about your health, your understanding of your cancer diagnosis and treatment, and your experiences before coming to the hospital. This will include questions from several standard questionnaires about:
 - Your general health literacy.
 - Your knowledge of cancer warning signs.
 - Your help-seeking behaviour, such as when and from whom you sought medical advice.
 - Your understanding of chemotherapy side effects.
- Provide some basic information about yourself (such as age, gender, education, and income) and details about your diagnosis and treatment, which will be collected from your medical records.
- The interview will be conducted in a **private room** at the Oncology Department of JPMC.
- Your participation in this study will be for **a single session only**; there will be no follow-up visits or additional requirements after this interview.

All procedures in this study are for research purposes only. There are no experimental or investigational procedures involved.

3. POSSIBLE RISKS OR DISCOMFORT

This study involves minimal risk. However, there are some potential risks or discomforts that you should be aware of:

Psychological/Emotional Risks

- Some questions may ask about your cancer diagnosis, symptoms you may have experienced, and your feelings about the challenges of treatment and seeking help. These topics may be sensitive or upsetting for some people.
- You may feel tired or emotionally drained after discussing your experiences.

Time and Inconvenience

- The interview will take approximately 30–45 minutes of your time.

Steps to Minimize Risks

- The interview will be conducted in a private, comfortable setting to ensure your privacy.
- You are free to **skip any question** you do not wish to answer.
- You may **take a break** at any time during the interview.
- You may **withdraw from the study at any time** without any penalty or effect on your medical care.
- If you experience significant emotional distress, you will be offered a referral to psychosocial support services within JPMC.
- The interviewer has been trained to be sensitive and respectful throughout the process.

Note: If any new information becomes available during the study that may affect your willingness to continue participation, you will be informed immediately.

4. POSSIBLE BENEFITS

Direct Benefits to You

- This study may not provide any direct medical or financial benefit to you personally.
- However, you may find it helpful to have the opportunity to discuss your experiences and be heard.

Benefits to Others

- The information collected will help healthcare providers and policymakers understand the role of health literacy in cancer outcomes in Pakistan.
- This knowledge will be used to develop better educational materials, community awareness programs, and support systems for future cancer patients, potentially helping them get diagnosed earlier and manage their treatment better.
- Your participation may help improve the well-being of future patients in Pakistan.

5. FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

- **There is no financial compensation** (payment) for participation in this research study.
- There are **no additional costs** to you for participating in this study.
- You will not be charged for the interview or any study-related procedures.
- If you are referred to psychosocial support services, these will be provided through existing JPMC services at no additional cost to you.

6. AVAILABLE TREATMENT ALTERNATIVES

This study does not involve any treatment, experimental or conventional. It is purely a research study involving a questionnaire interview. Your decision to participate or not will not affect the medical care or treatment that you or your family member receives at JPMC.

7. AVAILABLE MEDICAL TREATMENT FOR ADVERSE EXPERIENCES

This study involves **minimal risk**. However, if you experience significant emotional distress as a direct result of taking part in this research study:

- You will be offered a break or the option to stop the interview immediately.
- You may be referred to the psychosocial support or counseling services available at JPMC.
- The cost of any such counseling or support will be covered by JPMC as part of its existing services; you will not be charged.

In case of a research-related emergency, you may contact:

Contact	Information
Principal Investigator	Dr. Anita Vallacha (0336-8025062)

8. CONFIDENTIALITY

Your identity in this study will be treated as strictly confidential. The following steps will be taken to protect your privacy:

- Your name will **not** be recorded on any data collection forms. Instead, you will be assigned a unique **participant code number**.
- All paper records (consent forms, questionnaires) will be stored in a **locked cabinet** accessible only to the research team.
- Electronic data will be stored on **password-protected computers** with encrypted files.
- Only the research team will have access to any data that could identify you.

- The results of the study may be published for scientific purposes, but **your name or any identifiable information will never be included.**
- However, any records or data obtained as a result of your participation in this study may be inspected by authorized representatives of the **JPMC Institutional Review Board (IRB)** for audit and quality assurance purposes. These individuals are bound by confidentiality obligations.

9. RIGHTS TO PARTICIPATE, SAY NO, OR WITHDRAW

1. **Participation in this research project is completely voluntary.**
2. **You have the right to say no.** You may choose not to participate for any reason, and there will be no penalty or loss of benefits to which you are otherwise entitled.
3. **You may change your mind at any time and can withdraw** from the study without any consequences.
4. **Your decision will not affect** the medical care or treatment you receive at JPMC.
5. If you decide to withdraw, any data already collected from you will not be used and will be destroyed.

10. TERMINATION OF RESEARCH STUDY

- You are free to choose whether or not to participate or withdraw from this study. There will be **no penalty or loss of benefits** to which you are otherwise entitled if you choose not to participate.
- You will be provided with any significant new findings developed during the course of this study that may relate to or influence your willingness to continue participation.
- In the event you decide to discontinue your participation in the study:
 - **a)** There are no potential consequences for you; your withdrawal will be accepted without question.
 - **b)** Please notify the Principal Investigator (contact information below) of your decision, or simply inform the interviewer that you wish to stop.
- Your participation in the study may be terminated by the investigator without your consent under the following circumstances:
 - If you are unable to continue for any health-related reason.
 - If it becomes apparent that the study is causing you significant distress.
 - If the study is terminated by the IRB or for administrative reasons.

11. AVAILABLE SOURCES OF INFORMATION

If you have any questions about this study, your rights as a research participant, or if you have concerns or complaints, please contact any of the following:

For questions about the study:	For questions about your rights or concerns:
Name: Dr. Anita Vallacha	Name: JPMC Institutional Review Board (IRB) Secretariat
Phone: 0336-8025062	Phone: 021-99205185 (Ask for IRB Office)
Location: Oncology Department, JPMC, Karachi	Email: jpmc.edu.pk
	Location: Research Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre, Rafiqui Shaheed Road, Karachi

In case of a research-related emergency:

Day Emergency Number:	021-99205185 (JPMC Main Line)
Contact Person:	Oncology Department Staff

12. AUTHORIZATION

I have read and understand this consent form, and I volunteer to participate in this research study. I understand that I will receive a copy of this form. I voluntarily choose to participate, but I understand that my consent does not take away any legal rights.

Name of participant (Printed or Typed): _____

Date: _____

Signature of participant: _____

Date: _____

Signature of Principal Investigator: _____

Date: _____

Signature of person obtaining consent: _____

Date: _____

FOR ILLITERATE PARTICIPANTS (IMPARTIAL WITNESS PROCEDURE)

If the participant is unable to read this consent form, the following procedure will be followed:

1. The consent form will be **read aloud and explained** to the participant in their preferred language (Urdu, Sindhi, or English) by the interviewer or a trained translator.
2. An **impartial witness** (not affiliated with the research team) will be present during the entire consent process.
3. The participant will be given the opportunity to ask questions and will be encouraged to ask for clarification.
4. If the participant agrees to participate, their **verbal consent** will be documented, and the witness will sign this form confirming that the information was accurately explained and that the participant voluntarily agreed.

Thank you for considering participation in this important research study. Your contribution will help improve care and outcomes for cancer patients in Pakistan.